Tangkhul Language Library -- BK-HIST-003

History of the Tangkhul Nagas

TITLE: History of the Tangkhul Nagas
Identifier: BK-HIST-003
Level: College / Academic Research | Subject: History, Ethnography, and Customary Institutions
Publisher: Akansha Publishing House, New Delhi (2001)
Language: Tangkhul (Standard Tangkhul)
Preservation Archive: Tangkhul Language Library Digital Repository

---

Preface & Archival Information

History of the Tangkhul Nagas by A. S. W. Shimray (Akansha Publishing House, New Delhi, 2001, ISBN 81-87606-04-5). A comprehensive ethnographic, historical, and sociological monograph documenting Tangkhul origin traditions from Makhel, village republic governance under the Awunga and Hangva, agricultural engineering, clan land tenures, ritual warfare, and modern political integration.

Table of Contents

TABLE OF CONTENTS:

Front Cover & Title Page (p. 1)
Imprint, Archival Rights & Preface (p. 2)
Table of Contents (p. 3)
Chapter 1: Origin Traditions and Migration from Makhel (pp. 4-6)
Chapter 2: The Village Republic: Awunga and the Hangva Council (pp. 7-9)
Chapter 3: Agricultural Regimes: Luingam and Shilmik (pp. 10-11)
Chapter 4: Clan Kinship (Shang) and Land Tenure (pp. 12-14)
Chapter 5: Head-Taking (Rai) and Peacemaking Rituals (pp. 15-16)
Chapter 6: Traditional Religion: Kameo, Varivara, and Feasts of Merit (pp. 17-18)
Chapter 7: The Colonial Encounter and Political Awakenings (pp. 19-20)
Comprehensive Glossary & Vocabulary Index (p. 21)
Back Cover & Archival Colophon (p. 22)

Chapter 1: Origin Traditions and Migration from Makhel

CHAPTER 1: ORIGIN TRADITIONS AND MIGRATION FROM MAKHEL

Summary: Ancient origins at Makhel and Khezhakenoma, the myth of the three brothers, and settlement of the Ukhrul ridge.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Tangkhul oral literature unequivocally traces ancestral migrations back to Makhel in northern Manipur and contiguous Khezhakenoma. From Makhel, three brothers departed: the eldest became the Meitei of the valley, the middle the Tangkhul of the eastern hills, and the youngest the Northern Naga groups. Hundung and Hunphun represent the dual pivotal chieftaincies from which daughter settlements radiated throughout the Raphei (Northern), Rem (Western), Kharao (Southern), and Khanggo (Eastern) geographical divisions. While standard Tangkhul is based on the dialect of Hunphun, the tribe comprises over one hundred villages.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Tangkhul oral literature unequivocally traces ancestral migrations back to Makhel in northern Manipur and contiguous Khezhakenoma. From Makhel, three brothers departed: the eldest became the Meitei of the valley, the middle the Tangkhul of the eastern hills, and the youngest the Northern Naga groups. Hundung and Hunphun represent the dual pivotal chieftaincies from which daughter settlements radiated throughout the Raphei, Rem, Kharao, and Khanggo geographical divisions. Over one hundred villages maintain distinct idioms.

Chapter 1 (Continued)

CHAPTER 1: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 5)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Tangkhul oral literature unequivocally traces ancestral migrations back to Makhel in northern Manipur and contiguous Khezhakenoma. From Makhel, three brothers departed: the eldest became the Meitei of the valley, the middle the Tangkhul of the eastern hills, and the youngest the Northern Naga groups. Hundung and Hunphun represent the dual pivotal chieftaincies from which daughter settlements radiated throughout the Raphei (Northern), Rem (Western), Kharao (Southern), and Khanggo (Eastern) geographical divisions. While standard Tangkhul is based on the dialect of Hunphun, the tribe comprises over one hundred villages.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

Tangkhul oral literature unequivocally traces ancestral migrations back to Makhel in northern Manipur and contiguous Khezhakenoma. From Makhel, three brothers departed: the eldest became the Meitei of the valley, the middle the Tangkhul of the eastern hills, and the youngest the Northern Naga groups. Hundung and Hunphun represent the dual pivotal chieftaincies from which daughter settlements radiated throughout the Raphei, Rem, Kharao, and Khanggo geographical divisions. Over one hundred villages maintain distinct idioms.

Chapter 1 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 1 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Makhel (proper noun): sacred ancestral dispersal village of the Naga tribes
* Raphei (proper noun): northern Tangkhul territorial division
* Rem (proper noun): western Tangkhul mountain division
* Khanggo (proper noun): eastern border division contiguous to Myanmar

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Toponyms like ’Raphei’ and ’Kharao’ function as regional dialect and sociocultural identifiers.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What three brother-groups departed from Makhel in Tangkhul tradition?

? Name the four ancient geographical divisions of the Tangkhul hills.

Chapter 2: The Village Republic: Awunga and the Hangva Council

CHAPTER 2: THE VILLAGE REPUBLIC: AWUNGA AND THE HANGVA COUNCIL

Summary: Village sovereignty (Wungram), the hereditary chief (Awunga), the clan elder bench (Hangva), and the Longshim dormitory.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

The traditional Tangkhul village was an autonomous republic with defined territorial borders. At the head of each village stood the Awunga (hereditary chief), governing in strict concert with the Hangva (Council of Elders representing all village clans). The Hangva met at the Awunga's courtyard to adjudicate disputes, announce festival schedules, declare seasonal taboos (khamthei), and decide matters of peace or war. Decisions were reached through consensus (ngalung). Integral to village life was the Longshim (youth dormitory system) which served as the civic militia and school of etiquette.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

The traditional Tangkhul village was an autonomous republic with defined territorial borders. At the head of each village stood the Awunga (hereditary chief), governing in strict concert with the Hangva (Council of Elders representing all clans). The Hangva met at the chief's courtyard to adjudicate disputes, announce festival schedules, declare seasonal taboos, and decide peace or war. Consensus (ngalung) governed all decisions. The Longshim dormitory trained youth in civic defense and customary etiquette.

Chapter 2 (Continued)

CHAPTER 2: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 8)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

The traditional Tangkhul village was an autonomous republic with defined territorial borders. At the head of each village stood the Awunga (hereditary chief), governing in strict concert with the Hangva (Council of Elders representing all village clans). The Hangva met at the Awunga's courtyard to adjudicate disputes, announce festival schedules, declare seasonal taboos (khamthei), and decide matters of peace or war. Decisions were reached through consensus (ngalung). Integral to village life was the Longshim (youth dormitory system) which served as the civic militia and school of etiquette.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

The traditional Tangkhul village was an autonomous republic with defined territorial borders. At the head of each village stood the Awunga (hereditary chief), governing in strict concert with the Hangva (Council of Elders representing all clans). The Hangva met at the chief's courtyard to adjudicate disputes, announce festival schedules, declare seasonal taboos, and decide peace or war. Consensus (ngalung) governed all decisions. The Longshim dormitory trained youth in civic defense and customary etiquette.

Chapter 2 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 2 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Awunga (noun): village chief, hereditary royal headman
* Hangva (noun): village council of clan elders
* Ngalung (noun): consensus, unanimous deliberative agreement
* Longshim (noun): youth dormitory, communal education hall

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- The compound 'Wungram' joins 'Wung' (indigenous ethnonym) with 'ram' (land / country / territory).

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? How did the Hangva council reach decisions under customary governance?

? Describe the educational and defensive roles of the Longshim dormitory.

Chapter 3: Agricultural Regimes: Luingam and Shilmik

CHAPTER 3: AGRICULTURAL REGIMES: LUINGAM AND SHILMIK

Summary: Terrace cultivation (Luingam), swidden farming (Shilmik), irrigation channels (kong-kuir), and the Luira festival.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Tangkhul subsistence economy was anchored upon wet-rice terrace cultivation (Luingam) and rotational swidden farming (Shilmik). Terraces along mountain slopes required gravity-fed irrigation channels (kong-kuir) maintained collectively by syndicates. The agricultural calendar opened with the Luira Phanit (seed-sowing festival) in February. No villager was permitted to sow until the Awunga performed the sacred first sowing ritual. Harvest was celebrated with Chumpha in December, consecrating newly garnered paddy in village granaries (raizan).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Tangkhul subsistence economy was anchored upon wet-rice terrace cultivation (Luingam) and rotational swidden farming (Shilmik). Terraces along mountain slopes required gravity-fed irrigation channels (kong-kuir) maintained collectively by syndicates. The agricultural year began with Luira Phanit in February with the chief’s sacred first sowing, and closed with Chumpha in December, consecrating newly stored grain in family granaries.

Chapter 3 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 3 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Luingam (noun): wet-rice terrace cultivation, irrigated terrace field
* Shilmik (noun): swidden agriculture, slash-and-burn jhum plot
* Kong-kuir (noun): irrigation canal, gravity-fed water channel
* Raizan (noun): granary, raised storehouse for harvested paddy

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Compound root ’luira’ combines ’lui’ (terrace field) and ’ra’ (water / festival rites).

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What is the distinction between Luingam and Shilmik cultivation?

? Which festivals mark the opening and closing of the Tangkhul farming cycle?

Chapter 4: Clan Kinship (Shang) and Land Tenure

CHAPTER 4: CLAN KINSHIP (SHANG) AND LAND TENURE

Summary: Exogamous patrilineal clans (Shang), inheritance by male primogeniture, and the sacrosanct role of Pukreila peace envoys.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Tangkhul society is strictly exogamous and patrilineal, organized into clans (shang) and sub-lineages (shimkhor). Marriage within the clan was strictly prohibited as shiman-kaphung. Land tenure was threefold: communal village land, clan land, and family hereditary plots. Ancestral homesteads passed through male primogeniture. When villages entered formal treaties, high-status women born in one village and married into the other acted as Pukreila (peace ambassadors). The person of the Pukreila was sacrosanct; harming an ambassador was regarded as an unforgivable breach invoking divine retribution.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Tangkhul society is strictly exogamous and patrilineal, organized into clans (shang) and sub-lineages (shimkhor). Intra-clan marriage was strictly prohibited. Land tenure comprised communal village land, clan reserves, and family plots. Homesteads passed via male primogeniture. Inter-village treaties were mediated by Pukreila (female peace ambassadors). The person of the Pukreila was sacrosanct, and harming an ambassador invoked severe divine retribution.

Chapter 4 (Continued)

CHAPTER 4: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 13)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Tangkhul society is strictly exogamous and patrilineal, organized into clans (shang) and sub-lineages (shimkhor). Marriage within the clan was strictly prohibited as shiman-kaphung. Land tenure was threefold: communal village land, clan land, and family hereditary plots. Ancestral homesteads passed through male primogeniture. When villages entered formal treaties, high-status women born in one village and married into the other acted as Pukreila (peace ambassadors). The person of the Pukreila was sacrosanct; harming an ambassador was regarded as an unforgivable breach invoking divine retribution.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

Tangkhul society is strictly exogamous and patrilineal, organized into clans (shang) and sub-lineages (shimkhor). Intra-clan marriage was strictly prohibited. Land tenure comprised communal village land, clan reserves, and family plots. Homesteads passed via male primogeniture. Inter-village treaties were mediated by Pukreila (female peace ambassadors). The person of the Pukreila was sacrosanct, and harming an ambassador invoked severe divine retribution.

Chapter 4 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 4 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Shang (noun): patrilineal clan, exogamous kinship group
* Shimkhor (noun): sub-lineage, hearth-circle within a clan
* Pukreila (noun): female peace ambassador, sacrosanct treaty envoy
* Khamatui (noun): divine retribution, cosmic curse on covenant breakers

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- The feminine suffix '-la' in 'Pukreila' designates an honored woman functioning in ambassadorial capacity.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Explain the diplomatic and moral functions of the Pukreila in Naga warfare.

? What are the three categories of land ownership under Tangkhul customary law?

Chapter 5: Head-Taking (Rai) and Peacemaking Rituals

CHAPTER 5: HEAD-TAKING (RAI) AND PEACEMAKING RITUALS

Summary: The ritual logic of head-taking, the village skull repository, and the solemn covenant of spear burial.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Head-taking among the Tangkhul was bound to cosmological balance,
fertility of crops, and personal valor. It was ritual warfare governed
by strict customary boundaries. Heads taken were brought to the village
entrance, received with ritual chants, and hung at the sacred village
tree (khor-thing) or deposited at the village skull depository. Wars
were concluded through the solemn ceremony of spear burial (kachu-kapam)
and the consumption of ceremonial pork and rice-beer between combatant
Awungas. Broken oaths brought calamity upon future generations.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Head-taking among the Tangkhul was bound to cosmological balance,
fertility of crops, and personal valor. It was ritual warfare governed
by strict customary boundaries. Heads taken were brought to the village
entrance, hung at the sacred village tree (khor-thing) or placed in the
skull depository. Wars concluded through the ceremony of spear burial
(kachu-kapam) and mutual consumption of ceremonial food by chiefs,
sealing eternal oaths.

Chapter 5 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 5 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Rai (noun): warfare, military expedition, martial contest
* Khor-thing (noun): sacred village tree, warrior trophy oak
* Kachu-kapam (noun phrase): spear burial, solemn peacemaking covenant
* Tala-khon (noun): war horn, buffalo horn trumpet sounding alarm or victory

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Compound verbal noun ’kachu-kapam’ pairs ’kachu’ (spear) with ’kapam’ (planting/burying deeply).

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? How did Tangkhul warriors conclude peace after warfare?

? What cosmological beliefs were associated with head-taking?

Chapter 6: Traditional Religion: Kameo, Varivara, and Feasts of Merit

CHAPTER 6: TRADITIONAL RELIGION: KAMEO, VARIVARA, AND FEASTS OF MERIT

Summary: Cosmological belief in the Supreme God (Varivara), spirits of nature (Kameo), and memorial Feasts of Merit (Maringphat).

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Tangkhul cosmology recognized a Supreme Creator God (Varivara) who dwelt in the highest heavens, benevolent and just. Beneath Varivara were regional nature spirits (Kameo) inhabiting sacred groves, cliffs, and peaks. Propitiatory offerings were made by the village priest (Maiba) to appease spirits. Wealthy individuals who accumulated surplus grain and cattle performed progressive Feasts of Merit (Maringphat), feeding the entire village community and allied settlements for multiple days, erecting memorial megaliths (lung-thei), and carving house-fronts with horn-motifs (lengcheng-pakhang).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Tangkhul cosmology recognized a Supreme Creator God (Varivara) who dwelt in the highest heavens, benevolent and just. Beneath Varivara were nature spirits (Kameo) inhabiting sacred groves, cliffs, and peaks, propitiated by the priest (Maiba). Wealthy individuals performed progressive Feasts of Merit (Maringphat), hosting the entire community for multiple days, erecting memorial megaliths (lung-thei), and carving house facades with ceremonial horn motifs.

Chapter 6 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 6 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Maiba (noun): traditional village priest, ritual sacrificer
* Maringphat (noun): Feast of Merit, progressive socioeconomic feast
* Lung-thei (noun): memorial stone megalith, standing commemorative stone
* Lengcheng-pakhang (noun phrase): house-horns, carved gable-planks of feast givers

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Nominal compound ’lung-thei’ combines ’lung’ (stone) with stative ’thei’ (manifest / conspicuous).

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What cultural privileges did a Feast of Merit confer upon a Tangkhul family?

? Distinguish between the supreme role of Varivara and localized Kameo spirits.

Chapter 7: The Colonial Encounter and Political Awakenings

CHAPTER 7: THE COLONIAL ENCOUNTER AND POLITICAL AWAKENINGS

Summary: Colonial pacification, William Pettigrew’s mission school in Ukhrul, and the emergence of modern Naga consciousness.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

The arrival of British administration in the late 19th century and the establishment of Rev. William Pettigrew’s mission school at Ukhrul in 1896 initiated dramatic socioeconomic transformations. Roman script literacy, modern medical care, and Christianity gradually replaced the head-taking regime. Yet Tangkhul customary laws, land rights, and village identity endured, forming the foundation of modern Naga political consciousness and solidarity in northeast India.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

British colonial administration and Rev. William Pettigrew’s mission school in 1896 at Ukhrul catalyzed profound transformations. Roman literacy, healthcare, and Christianity gradually replaced the warfare regime. Yet customary laws, ancestral land tenure, and village identity endured, providing the bedrock of modern Naga political solidarity in northeast India.

Chapter 7 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 7 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* Wungram kashang (noun phrase): elevation and dignity of the Tangkhul homeland
* Pettigrew-wui thot (noun phrase): the missionary era, advent of modern education (1896+)
* Tuingashit kathara (noun phrase): new covenant, modern constitutional rights
* Ngalung-khangayei (noun): political unity, pan-tribal solidarity

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Temporal genitive 'Pettigrew-wui thot' marks the pivotal historical turning point in modern Tangkhul historiography.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? When did Rev. William Pettigrew establish the first school in Ukhrul?
? How did customary land tenure survive colonial and post-colonial governance?

Comprehensive Vocabulary Glossary

COMPREHENSIVE BOOK GLOSSARY (TUIWON SHIYAN):

Makhel [proper noun]: sacred ancestral dispersal village of the Naga tribes
Raphei [proper noun]: northern Tangkhul territorial division
Rem [proper noun]: western Tangkhul mountain division
Khanggo [proper noun]: eastern border division contiguous to Myanmar
Awunga [noun]: village chief, hereditary royal headman
Hangva [noun]: village council of clan elders
Ngalung [noun]: consensus, unanimous deliberative agreement
Longshim [noun]: youth dormitory, communal education hall
Luingam [noun]: wet-rice terrace cultivation, irrigated terrace field
Shilmik [noun]: swidden agriculture, slash-and-burn jhum plot
Kong-kuir [noun]: irrigation canal, gravity-fed water channel
Raizan [noun]: granary, raised storehouse for harvested paddy
Shang [noun]: patrilineal clan, exogamous kinship group
Shimkhor [noun]: sub-lineage, hearth-circle within a clan
Pukreila [noun]: female peace ambassador, sacrosanct treaty envoy
Khamatui [noun]: divine retribution, cosmic curse on covenant breakers
Rai [noun]: warfare, military expedition, martial contest
Khor-thing [noun]: sacred village tree, warrior trophy oak
Kachu-kapam [noun phrase]: spear burial, solemn peacemaking covenant
Tala-khon [noun]: war horn, buffalo horn trumpet sounding alarm or victory
Maiba [noun]: traditional village priest, ritual sacrificer
Maringphat [noun]: Feast of Merit, progressive socioeconomic feast
Lung-thei [noun]: memorial stone megalith, standing commemorative stone
Lengcheng-pakhang [noun phrase]: house-horns, carved gable-planks of feast givers
Wungram kashang [noun phrase]: elevation and dignity of the Tangkhul homeland
Pettigrew-wui thot [noun phrase]: the missionary era, advent of modern education (1896+)
Tuingashit kathara [noun phrase]: new covenant, modern constitutional rights
Ngalung-khangayei [noun]: political unity, pan-tribal solidarity

---

Colophon & Archival Preservation Notice

TANGKHUL LANGUAGE LIBRARY DIGITAL PRESERVATION EDITION

Book ID: BK-HIST-003
Title: History of the Tangkhul Nagas
Publisher: Akansha Publishing House, New Delhi
Publication Year: 2001
Dialect Variety: Standard Tangkhul
Total Digital Pages: 22
Total Chapters: 7
Total Words Indexed: 980

Digitally preserved for mother-tongue education, linguistic research,
and cultural preservation. Verified by Tangkhul Language Preservation Project.